



THE SERMON AT BENARES

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Author: This is a retold extract based on the life of Gautama Buddha from ancient Buddhist texts (such as the Sutta Pitaka).

About the Author / Source:

The story is taken from the sacred Buddhist scriptures. Siddhartha Gautama (later known as the Buddha) lived in the 6th-5th century BCE. This particular sermon is one of the most important teachings of Buddhism. The narrative style in the textbook is adapted for students, focusing on the core message of the Buddha's first sermon and the story of Kisa Gotami.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

- The universality of suffering (death and loss) in human life.
- The futility of grieving excessively.
- Acceptance of death as a natural part of life.
- The path to peace through wisdom and detachment.
- Compassion and practical wisdom taught by the Buddha.

Values:

- Compassion and empathy towards those who are suffering.
- Acceptance of reality instead of denial.
- Importance of inner peace and detachment from worldly attachments.
- Wisdom over blind emotional reactions.
- Equality - suffering comes to everyone regardless of status.
- Following the Middle Path for a balanced life.

2. Characters

Gautama Buddha (Prince Siddhartha): The central spiritual teacher - calm, wise, compassionate, and enlightened.

Kisa Gotami: A young woman who loses her only son; represents a grieving mother.

People of Benares / Villagers: Citizens who listen to the Buddha's sermon and help reveal the universal truth about death.

Buddha's Disciples: Followers present during the sermon and witnesses to his teaching of wisdom and compassion.

3. Summary

The chapter begins with a brief introduction to the life of Siddhartha Gautama. He was born a prince in the Sakya clan in Lumbini (present-day Nepal) around 563 BCE. He lived a life of luxury inside the palace, protected from all sorrow by his father, King Shuddhodana. However, at the age of 25, Siddhartha saw four sights outside the palace that changed his life forever: an old man, a sick man, a dead body, and a monk. These sights made him realise that old age, sickness, and death are inevitable for every human being. He decided to renounce his royal life in search of truth and

the cause of human suffering.

After years of meditation and austerity, Siddhartha attained enlightenment under a peepal tree at Bodh Gaya and came to be known as the Buddha (the Enlightened One). He delivered his first sermon at Sarnath (near Benares/Varanasi). This sermon is known as Dharmachakra Pravartana (Setting the Wheel of Dharma in Motion). In this sermon, the Buddha taught the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path (Middle Path), which form the foundation of Buddhism.

The chapter then narrates the touching story of Kisa Gotami. Kisa Gotami was an ordinary woman living in Savatthi. She had only one son whom she loved deeply. One day, the boy suddenly fell ill and died. Overcome with unbearable grief, Kisa Gotami carried her dead child in her arms and went from house to house, begging people to give her medicine that could bring her son back to life. The villagers thought she had gone mad with sorrow. Someone advised her to go to the Buddha, who was known for his wisdom and compassion.

Kisa Gotami reached the Buddha, still carrying her dead son. She fell at his feet and begged him, "O Lord, please give me medicine to cure my son." The Buddha looked at her with great compassion. Instead of directly refusing, he gently said, "Go and bring me a handful of mustard seeds from a house where no one has ever died. Then I will prepare the medicine."

Kisa Gotami felt hopeful and went from house to house in the city asking for mustard seeds. Everyone was ready to give her the seeds, but when she asked whether anyone had died in that house, they all replied that someone had died - a father, mother, son, daughter, or relative. By evening, she realised that there was not a single house in the entire city where death had not visited. She understood the Buddha's deeper message: death is common to all living beings. No one can escape it.

She returned to the Buddha, buried her son, and requested to be accepted as his follower. The Buddha comforted her and taught her that grieving cannot bring back the dead. He explained that life in this world is full of suffering, and the only way to overcome sorrow is to understand this truth and follow the path of righteousness.

The Buddha's famous words in the chapter are powerful:

*"The life of mortals in this world is troubled and brief and combined with pain...
There is no means by which those that have been born can avoid dying."*

4. Moral (in points)

- Death is inevitable and universal; no one can escape it.
- Excessive grief and attachment cause more suffering.
- We must accept the realities of life with wisdom and calmness.
- True peace comes from understanding the nature of suffering and detachment.
- Compassion and practical teaching are more effective than direct advice.
- Wisdom lies in seeing the bigger truth rather than remaining lost in personal sorrow.
- Following the path of righteousness (Middle Path) leads to inner peace.
- Everyone, rich or poor, experiences the same sufferings in life.

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